

■ Gambler's Fallacy

■ What is it?

People believe past events can influence future events—even when they don't.

The Gambler's Fallacy is the mistaken belief that if something happens repeatedly, the opposite outcome is "due" to occur.

For example, if a coin lands on heads five times in a row, people assume tails is guaranteed next. But each flip is still 50/50, no matter what came before.

■■ History

The term comes from gambling studies in the **19th century**, when researchers noticed gamblers often believed losing streaks must eventually "balance out."

This false logic caused people to make poor betting decisions in casinos—believing random chance had a memory.

Today, the same thinking shows up in gaming, investing, product use, and everyday decision-making.

■ The Psychology Behind It

- The human brain loves **patterns**, even in randomness.
- When we see streaks (wins, losses, or failures), we expect things to "even out."
- This creates false confidence, frustration, or risky decisions.

■■ Why It Matters

The Gambler's Fallacy can lead to:

- Misguided user expectations
- Frustration with random or reward systems
- Drop-offs when perceived "luck" runs out
- Poor decision-making in repeated actions
- Misinterpretation of fairness or success

■ How to Apply It

- **Clarify randomness** → explain how rewards or outcomes really work.
- **Be transparent** → show odds, availability, or wait times.
- **Avoid misleading streaks** → don't suggest false "due" events.
- **Provide feedback** → e.g., "This is random, try again."
- **Balance retries** → reduce frustration with variety or guaranteed rewards after several attempts.

■ Theory in Action

- **FIFA Ultimate Team** players often believe that after many failed attempts, a rare card is "due," which keeps them spending.
- **Lottery players** avoid numbers that were drawn recently, thinking they won't come up again—despite every draw being independent.

■ Final Thought

People naturally search for patterns, even in pure chance.

Good design means being **clear, fair, and transparent** about randomness. That way, users don't feel tricked by "luck" and can engage with confidence.